

Assignment 2: Sentence Simplification and Inference Questions

Post-it® Notes

1 One of the world's most well-known, and seemingly simple, products took several years and a series of unexpected yet fortunate events to come to light. The start of what would become Post-it® Notes came in the late 1960s at the 3M company in Minnesota quite by accident.

Researchers at 3M were working on developing different types of adhesives, and one particularly weak adhesive, a compound of acrylate copolymer microspheres, was formulated.

Employees at 3M were asked if they could think of a use for weak adhesive, which, provided it did not get dirty, could be reused. For several years the adhesive was shelved, as employees of the organization could not find a suitable, marketable use for the sticky substance. Yet, the mild adhesive stayed on the workers' minds, and years later, their persistence would pay off.

2 It wasn't until the mid-seventies that a 3M researcher thought of a practical and convenient use for the adhesive. Tired of losing his place in a book he used often, the researcher suggested his associate's sticky innovation could be applied to a piece of paper to be used as a bookmark that would stay in place in a book.

Another use was found when the product was attached to a report that was to be sent to a coworker with a request for comments on the report; the colleague made his comments on the paper attached to the report and returned the report. Thus, the idea for Post-it® Notes was born.

3 It was decided within the company that there would be a test launch of the product in 1977 in four American cities. Sales of this innovative product in test cities were less than stellar, most likely because the product, while innovative, was also quite unfamiliar. A final attempt was then made in the city of Boise to introduce the product. In this attempt, 3M salesmen gave demonstrations of the product in offices throughout Boise while simultaneously offering free samples of the sticky notes to their audiences. When the salesmen returned a week later to the sites where the product had initially

been demonstrated and handed out, a huge percentage of the office workers, having noted how useful the tiny adhesive pieces of paper were, showed great interest in purchasing the Post-it® Notes.

4 Interestingly, the use of yellow for the early notes also came about through chance. In their rush to test the original paper, 3M employees picked up scrap paper that had been discarded by another department and applied the adhesive to the back of the sheets. When testing and first taking the product to market, the company continued the use of canary yellow as the color of the notes, perhaps for consistency's sake, or perhaps because the bright color made it easy to distinguish when laid against the typical white of most book and report pages of the era.

5 Over time, 3M came to understand the huge potential of this new product, and over the next few decades more than 400 varieties of Post-it® products—in varying colors, shapes, and sizes—have been promoted, most with success that has paralleled the original product's showing in Boise. Other competitors noticed the remarkable success of the Post-it® products as well. When 3M's original patent on Post-its® expired in the 1990s, rival companies flooded the market with products similar to those 3M had exclusively marketed for years. While the competitors are allowed to replicate the formula and general design of Post-it® Notes, there are two elements of the product that are off-limits: the name Post-it®, which has been copyrighted by 3M, and the initial color of original Post-its®, canary yellow, which 3M also claims sole use of.

6 Today, the use of Post-it® Notes has expanded beyond their primary functions as a convenient marker for extra notes and memos, and a placeholder for readers. Artists of all types have imagined diverse roles for the notes and have made them the central components of more than one art exhibit. The tiny colorful pieces of paper have been used to create art images, or served as the canvasses for portraits and murals. In the early 2000s, the play *Inside a Bigger Box* was opened in conjunction with an international art show consisting entirely of works inspired by or created with Post-it® Notes.

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1. Which of the sentences below best expresses the essential information in the highlighted sentence in paragraph 1 ?

- A. Of the many adhesives that were being developed at 3M, one was not a particularly strong adhesive.
- B. Researchers at 3M spent many years trying to develop a really weak adhesive.
- C. Numerous weak adhesives resulted from a program to develop the strongest adhesive of all.
- D. Researchers were assigned to develop different types of uses for acrylate copolymer microspheres.

2. Which of the sentences below best expresses the essential information in the highlighted sentence in paragraph 2?

- A. The 3M company suggested applying for a patent on the product in a report prepared by a colleague.
- B. One unexpectedly discovered use for the adhesive was in sending and receiving notes attached to documents.
- C. A note was attached to a report asking for suggestions for uses of one of 3M's products.
- D. A colleague who developed the new product kept notes with suggestions by other workers.

3. Which of the sentences below best expresses the essential information in the highlighted sentence in paragraph 3?

- A. When the salesmen went back to the places where they had demonstrated Post-it® Notes, they discovered that many office workers had already purchased the product.
- B. Though office workers found the small adhesive notes to be useful, the salesmen left after demonstrating and handing out the product.
- C. Salesmen who showed the Post-it® Notes and left samples for office workers returned a week later to sell the product.
- D. Many office workers wanted to buy the practical tiny sticky notes that salesmen

had demonstrated and left samples of a week earlier.

4. Which of the sentences below best expresses the essential information in the highlighted sentence in paragraph 4?

- A. The company tested the canary yellow color, but ultimately decided to continue to sell the notes in white, which was easier to distinguish at that time.
- B. The canary yellow color showed itself to be popular in tests for books and reports, so the company used the same color for the Post-it® Notes when they first went to market.
- C. The company had a choice of colors for the first Post-it® Notes but decided to use the bright yellow paper it had first chosen, since it would be consistent.
- D. The company kept using the bright yellow for Post-it® Notes, even when the product was first sold, possibly because it wanted to keep the same color or maybe because it was a good contrast color for the notes.

5. Which of the sentences below best expresses the essential information in the highlighted sentence in paragraph 5?

- A. Although competitors can replicate Post-it® Notes, they must change the colors and names of their products so they are not the same as those of 3M.
- B. Competitors can use the same adhesive and shape of Post-it® Notes, but they are not allowed to use the name or the yellow color, both of which belong to 3M alone.
- C. Competitors can produce notes like Post-it® Notes, but they cannot use the name, color, shape, or formula of the original.
- D. Because Post-it® Notes are so competitive, only the shape and adhesive remain the same; the yellow color and name has changed.

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The Golden Age of Comics

1 The period from the late 1930s until after the end of World War II is known as the Golden Age of Comics. The modern comic book came about in the early 1930s in the United States as a giveaway premium to promote the sales of a whole range of household products such as cereal and cleansers. The comic books, which were printed in bright colors to attract the attention of potential customers, proved so popular that some publishers decided to produce comic books that would come out on a monthly basis and would sell for a dime each. Though comic strips had been reproduced in publications prior to this time, the Famous Funnies comic book, which was started in 1934, marked the first occasion that a serialized book of comics was attempted.

2 The precise event that initiated the Golden Age of Comics has been debated for decades; nevertheless, virtually all comic book experts agree that the introduction of Superman in 1938 changed the concept of comic books, as well as their perception in the eyes of the public. Previously, comic books had focused on reprints of already existing comic strips. However, the enormous popularity of Superman ushered in an entire generation of original characters known as superheroes, many of which remain popular today. Shortly after Superman arrived on the scene, Batman, The Flash, The Green Lantern, and Wonder Woman were created, along with a host of others. The superheroes varied widely in their backgrounds, appearances, and superpowers, yet all shared one characteristic in common: a noble compulsion to protect the United States—and later the world—against evil.

3 At the start of the Golden Age of Comics, many Americans were in despair and only slowly recovering from the effects of the Great Depression. Comics debuted as an inexpensive way to entertain children and young adults who were not able to afford the cost of a movie ticket.

Perhaps because of their impoverished target audience, the first “villains” were often the wealthy owners of industry or powerful politicians. These prominent figures were portrayed as corrupt and unconcerned about the “common man,” and were almost always thoroughly defeated by the end of the comic book issue. Although some villains were able to escape after their losses to return in a later storyline, ultimately the conquering superhero always came out on top.

4 As the United States entered into World War II, new characters emerged that reflected the struggles Americans faced with their opposition overseas. The superheroes were recruited to battle against the same foreign forces American soldiers faced, though in the comic books, the negative characteristics of the opposing militaries were exaggerated and embellished in order to make the adventures more dramatic and thrilling for readers at home. Popular storylines exhibited patriotism and presented the ultimate resolution of good defeating evil.

5 The post-war demand for comic books fell off sharply from previous years, though this did not necessarily mean a decrease in the popularity of superheroes. While Superman, Batman, and other superheroes continued to be featured in traditional comic book formats, they also began to come to life in other media, especially films and television shows. Thus, even as the Golden Age of Comics began its inevitable decline, the enormous contribution of its superheroes to the popular culture of the United States has ensured that its significance will not be forgotten.

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17. It can be inferred from paragraph 1 that, at the beginning of the 1930s, comic books most likely cost
- A. nothing
 - B. five cents
 - C. ten cents
 - D. twenty-five cents
18. Comic books would least likely have been used to promote
- A. soap
 - B. cookies
 - C. jewelry
 - D. bread
19. It is implied in paragraph 2 that
- A. the start of the comic book's popularity has been precisely determined
 - B. Superman was not a popular figure when he first came out
 - C. it took decades for comic books to reach their Golden Age
 - D. not everyone agrees on what first caused comic books to gain popularity
20. From the information in paragraph 2, it appears that Superman most likely
- A. was introduced sometime after Batman
 - B. was a character that first appeared in a comic book
 - C. first appeared in the early 1930s
 - D. was the most popular superhero of his time
21. It can be inferred from paragraph 3 that the villains in comic books
- A. were eventually regarded as heroes by people after the Great Depression
 - B. sometimes defeated the superheroes in early comic books
 - C. were ones people in the 1930s liked to see defeated
 - D. were always killed at the end of a fight in comic books during their golden age
22. It can be inferred from the passage that
- A. comic book storylines were influenced by Americans' real-life struggles
 - B. comic books helped Americans understand the reality of the world around them
 - C. comic books remain as popular today as they were decades ago
 - D. comic books had no lasting impact once the Golden Age ended
23. Paragraph 4 suggests that
- A. comic books promoted Americans' devotion to their country
 - B. comic books depicted the domestic troubles in the U.S. at the time
 - C. comic books reached their height of excellence after World War II was over
 - D. overseas popularity of military-themed comic books was highest during World War II
24. What is implied in paragraph 5?
- A. Superman remains the most popular superhero.
 - B. Superheroes became less popular as comic books declined.
 - C. Superheroes remain popular in modern times.
 - D. Films and television have influenced the popularity of superheroes more than comic books.